



Saint Columban College
College of Computing Studies
Pagadian City



Obedient Cat

Obedient Cat 



Easy

General Skills

picoCTF 2021

AUTHOR: SYREAL

Description

This file has a flag in plain sight (aka "in-the-clear").

[flag](#)

Hints

1 2 3

Any hints about entering a command into the Terminal (such as the next one), will start with a '\$'... everything after the dollar sign will be typed (or copy and pasted) into your Terminal.

329,007 users solved



91%

Liked



 picoCTF{FLAG}

Submit
Flag

Author: The Analyst: Hyposelenia

Challenge: Obedient Cat

Category: General Skills

Date: 01/02/26



I. Objective

The objective of this task was to identify the hidden flag that was described as being “**in plain sight**.” The challenge focused on recognizing that the flag did not require complex decoding or advanced tools, but rather careful observation and an appropriate method of viewing the file.

II. Background

In many digital forensics and cybersecurity challenges, files are intentionally provided without clear identifiers such as file extensions. Operating systems like Windows rely heavily on file extensions to determine how a file should be opened and which application should be associated with it. When an extension is missing, the file may appear unknown or unusable at first glance. However, this does not mean the file’s contents are inaccessible. Since all digital files ultimately consist of characters or binary data, they can still be inspected using basic tools. The challenge description stating that the flag was “*hidden in plain sight*” strongly suggested that the solution involved directly viewing the file’s contents rather than transforming or decrypting it.

III. Tool Used

- **Notepad**

Although the file type was unknown in a Windows context, **Notepad** was used to inspect the raw contents of the file. Even if a file is not a standard text file, opening it with a text editor can reveal readable characters, patterns, or strings that may contain meaningful information such as a flag.

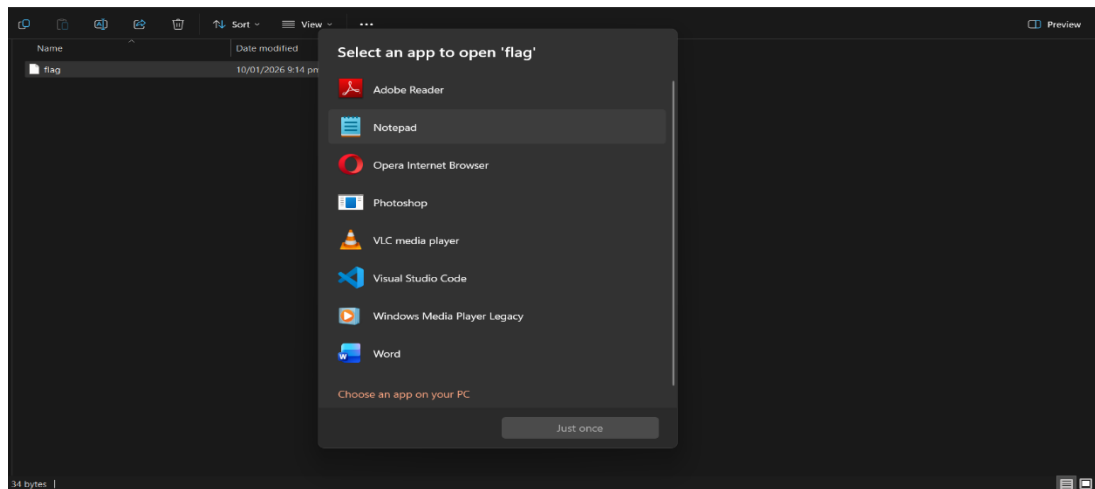


IV. Methodology

1. The file provided in the challenge was downloaded to the local system.

Name	Date modified	Type	Size
flag	10/01/2026 9:14 pm	File	1 KB

2. Upon inspection, the file had no extension, making it unclear whether it was an image, executable, archive, or text-based file.



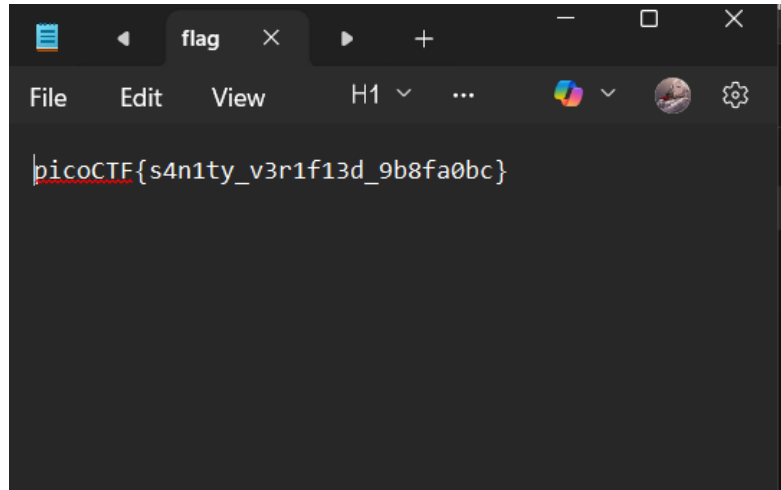
3. The file was opened using Notepad to view its raw contents.
4. Once opened, readable characters were immediately visible within the file.



5. These visible characters were examined carefully to locate the flag, based on the challenge hint that it was present in plain sight.

V. Result

picoCTF{s4n1ty_v3r1f13d_9b8fa0bc}



VI. Explanation

Upon examining the downloaded file named "flag," Windows was unable to determine its type due to the absence of a file extension. As a result, the operating system could not automatically associate it with a specific program. When double-clicked, Windows prompted the user to choose an application, such as Adobe Reader, Notepad, or Photoshop.

Windows relies on file extensions to identify file types and determine how they should be handled. Without this information, the file appears ambiguous. However, regardless of whether the file is an image, video, executable, or archive, it still contains underlying data that can be viewed at a basic level.

Given that the **challenge explicitly stated that the flag was hidden in plain sight**, opening the file with Notepad was a logical approach. By doing so, the raw characters within the file became visible. Even if some of the data appeared as unreadable symbols or binary-like characters, the flag itself was clearly present and readable. In essence, no decoding or extraction was necessary; the solution simply required viewing the file's contents directly.



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VII. Conclusion

This challenge demonstrated the importance of understanding how files are represented and handled by operating systems. It reinforced the idea that a missing file extension does not prevent access to a file's contents. By using a simple and commonly available tool like Notepad, the flag was successfully identified without the need for advanced techniques. The task highlighted that sometimes the simplest approach—carefully observing what is already visible—is sufficient to solve a problem.

— **The Analyst: Hyposelenia**